

‘Uyūn al-Rasā’il wa-l-Masā’il – No. 5

**Ruling on the Takfīr of a Specific Individual
And the Difference Between the Establishment
of the Proof and the Understanding of the Proof**

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بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

Introduction

Praise be to Allah, the One who helps, and may peace and blessings be upon the trustworthy Prophet, and upon his family, his Companions, and those who followed them.

To proceed:

The issue of declaring others disbelievers (takfīr), declaring them misguided (taḍlīl), and declaring them innovators (tabdīʿ) is an issue that has roots in the history of the Islamic sects. It was a prominent characteristic and distinguishing mark of the Khawārij and those who followed their way.

Then it became a means of defamation, so many people rode upon it, held firmly to it, and used it as a means to attack those who had realized tawḥīd and adherence to the Sunnah, ultimately seeking to broaden the circle of Islam even if this required overlooking manifest acts of Kufr.

The movement of renewal and reform in the twelfth century, however, placed a cloak of concealment over this issue by thinking well of Muslims and judging them according to what was contained in their hearts and what was apparent in their actions. From this general issue branched the specific question of declaring a particular individual a Kafir: Does this require the establishment of the proof, or must the person also understand the proof?

Al Allamah, Al Muhaddith, Shaykh Ishāq ibn ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Ibn Ḥasan Āl al-Shaykh, who died in 1319 AH, discussed the subject, expressed his position concerning it, and revisited it.

He expressed his doctrinal approach and clarified the Itiqad of his Salaf by presenting the evidences and proofs of the Sharī'ah that correspond with the recognized beneficial interests.

Perhaps the honorable reader will find what he seeks within the pages of this brief treatise.

Its author was among those who lived in various regions, traveled through different lands, and saw the manifestations of Kufr and Bid'ah among the common masses who attributed themselves to Islam.

Since the subject of the treatise remains the talk of the hour, we wished to publish it as a contribution toward enlightenment.

Among the things we regret is that we found only one copy, written by 'Abd al-'Azīz ibn Fawzān, which he prepared during the lifetime of the author in the year 1312 AH. He mentioned that he had copied it from the author's own handwriting.

As far as possible, some spelling errors and a very small amount of grammatical wording have been corrected.

I ask Allah for reward and a good recompense.

And Allah knows best. May Allah send peace and blessings upon our Prophet Muḥammad.

Ismā'īl ibn Sa'd ibn 'Atīq
Riyadh, 19/11/1408 AH

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

In the name of Allah, the Most Merciful, the Especially Merciful. Praise be to Allah, Lord of the worlds. There is no hostility except against the wrongdoers, and the good end is for the righteous. I bear witness that there is no deity worthy of worship except Allah, the One, the Self-Sufficient, Who alone is called upon in times of hardship and to Whom alone supplication is made.

Whoever worships other than Him is a Mushrik and Kafir, according to the explicit text of the Qur'an.

And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and Messenger, His beloved friend. May Allah's peace and blessings be upon him, his family, and all his Companions. Through him, the proof was established against all mankind; there is no prophet or messenger after him.

To proceed:

We have been informed and have heard from a group of people who claim to possess knowledge and religion, and who claim to follow Shaykh Muhammad ibn 'Abd al-Wahhāb, that whoever commits shirk with Allah and worships idols cannot be declared a Kafir or Mushrik specifically by name.

This is because some of those whom I personally encountered regarding this matter heard from some of the brothers that he had declared a man to be guilty of Shirk and Kufr because that man called upon the Prophet ﷺ and sought his help. The man then said to him: "Do not declare him a Kafir until you make him understand."

These people and others like them did not consider it a problem to associate with the Mushrikeen while traveling or living in their lands.

Rather, they sought knowledge from those who were among the most disbelieving of the scholars of the Mushrikeen.

They had fabricated various doubts and arguments to support their claim, some of which will appear during this treatise, if Allah تعالى wills.

Through these doubts, they deceived some of the common people among their followers, as well as those who had no knowledge of the matter, who did not know their true condition and could not distinguish between the different positions.

They became partisan: physically distancing themselves from the brothers while being attached to the Mashayikh in their hearts, and flattering them.

They became estranged from the brothers, and the brothers became estranged from them, because of the doubts they had displayed and because of the visible discomfort they showed regarding association with the sinful and polytheistic people.

Yet, upon careful examination, they do not declare the Mushrikeen to be a Kuffar except in general terms; among themselves, they refrain from doing so out of excessive caution.

Then their bid'ah and doubts gradually spread until they gained acceptance even among some of the closest and most trusted of the brothers.

And Allah knows best, this occurred because of abandoning the books of foundational principles (uṣūl), failing to give them proper attention, and not fearing deviation.

They turned away from the treatises of Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb may Allah sanctify his soul and the treatises of his sons, for these are more than sufficient to clarify all of these doubts, as anyone with even the slightest knowledge can see. If one observes the condition of the people today and examines the beliefs of the aforementioned shaykhs, he will be extremely perplexed. There is no might and no power except with Allah.

This is because one of those whom we referred to earlier was questioned about this issue. He said:

“We say to the people of these domes, those who worship them and those buried within them: ‘Your action is shirk, but you are not a mushrik.’”

Look and consider, and praise your Lord and ask Him for well-being. This answer is one of the answers of al-‘Irāqī (1) which Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf refuted.

The person who related this to me mentioned that one of the students asked him about this matter and about their evidence. He replied:

“We declare the type to be Kufr, but we do not declare the individual person to be a Kafir until after explaining the matter to him. Our evidence is what we saw in some of the treatises of Shaykh Muḥammad may Allah sanctify his soul in which he refrained from declaring ignorant people who worshipped the dome of al-Kawwāz and ‘Abd al-Qādir to be Kuffar because there was no one to alert them.”

(1) He is Dāwūd ibn Jirjīs. Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf refuted him in his book Minhāj al-Ta’sīs wa-l-Taqdīs.

Look and consider this astonishing matter, then ask Allah for well-being and that He protect you from reversing after progressing.

How similar they are to the well-known story about Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb رحمه الله . One day, he was explaining the Usul Al Deen and clarifying what they entailed.

One of the men sitting with him neither asked questions, expressed amazement, nor investigated anything, until the Shaykh reached one particular statement that contained something significant.

The man then said:

“What is this? How can that be?”

The Shaykh replied:

“May Allah destroy you! Our discussion has been going on since today began, yet you neither understood nor asked about it. Then, when this slip occurred, you recognized it! You are like a fly: it only lands upon filth.”

Or words to that effect.

And we say: Praise be to Allah; to Him belongs all praise. We ask Him for assistance and correctness. We say only what our shaykhs said: Shaykh Muḥammad in *Ifādat al-Mustafīd*, and his grandson in his refutation of al-‘Irāqī. This was likewise the position of the Imams of the religion before them.

And among those matters that are known necessarily as part of the religion of Islam is that, in matters of the Usul Al Deen, the reference is to the Qur’an, the Sunnah, and the recognized Ijma of the ummah, that is, what the Sahabah were upon. The reference is not to a particular scholar in such matters.

Whoever firmly establishes this principle in his mind in a manner that no doubt can undermine, and embraces it wholeheartedly, will find it easy to deal with statements he may encounter that appear ambiguous in some of the writings of his A'immah, for no one is infallible except the Prophet ﷺ.

Our particular issue, namely, worshipping Allah alone, without partner, disavowing the worship of anything besides Him, and that whoever worships another alongside Allah has committed major shirk that expels him from the religion, is the Usul of Usul. It is for this reason that Allah sent the Messengers, revealed the Books, and established the proof against mankind through the Messenger and the Qur'an.

Likewise, when you examine the answers of the A'immah of the religion concerning this Usul, you find that when making Takfir on someone who commits shirk with Allah, they state that he is asked to repent; if he repents, he is left alone, and if he does not repent, he is killed.

They do not mention “making him understand the proof” (al-ta'rīf) in Masa'il Al Usul. Rather, they mention it in hidden matters, whose evidence may be unclear to some Muslimeen, such as issues over which some of Ahl Al Bid'ah disputed, like the Qadariyyah and Murji'ah, or an hidden issue such as al-ṣarf and al-'aṭf.

And how could the grave-worshippers be “made to understand” when they are not Muslims in the first place and do not fall under the designation of Islam?

And does any righteous deed remain alongside shirk?

Allah تعالى says:

“nor will they enter Paradise until a camel enters into the eye of a needle.” [Qur’an 7:40]

“And he who associates with Allah – it is as though he had fallen from the sky and was snatched by the birds or the wind carried him down into a remote place.” [Qur’an 22:31]

“Indeed, Allah does not forgive association with Him.” [Qur’an 4:48]

And other verses besides these.

However, this belief necessarily entails a repugnant conclusion: that the proof has not been established against this Ummah, through the Messenger and the Qur’an. We seek refuge in Allah from the evil of misunderstanding which caused them to forget the Book and the Messenger.

As for Ahl al-Fatrah, those to whom the message and the Qur’an did not reach, and who died upon the state of Jahiliyyah, they are not called Muslims by Ijma, nor is forgiveness sought for them. Rather, the scholars differed concerning whether they will be punished in the Akhirah.

This doubt that we have mentioned, or something similar to it, occurred to some people during the time of Shaykh Muḥammad may Allah have mercy on him. But whoever encountered such a doubt regarded it as a doubt requiring clarification and sought to have it resolved.

As for those whom we have mentioned, they have made this doubt into a fundamental, declaring that the generality of the Mushrikeen must first be given an explanation, and they consider those who disagree with them to be ignorant. Thus, they are not granted success in reaching what is correct, because they have a personal inclination in this matter namely, associating and mixing with the Mushrikeen.

“[Who say], “Our Lord, let not our hearts deviate after You have guided us.”

[Qur'an 3:8]

Allah Akbar! How many people have deviated while they do not even realize it!

We have mentioned this introduction so that it may better prepare the reader to understand the evidences that will follow concerning this issue.

A Letter from Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb Concerning This Issue :—

Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb, may Allah sanctify his soul said in the letter he wrote to Aḥmad ibn ‘Abd al-Karīm, a righteous man from al-Aḥsā’, before he became afflicted by this matter. We will mention part of it because of its similarity to the position of the one whom we are refuting, such as the author of the letter. This is its text:

“From Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb to Aḥmad ibn ‘Abd al-Karīm. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to Allah, Lord of the worlds.

To proceed: I received your letter in which you established the issue you mentioned and stated that you had encountered a difficulty for which you sought clarification. Then I received another letter from you in which you mentioned that you had come across the words of Shaykh al-Islām, which removed the difficulty for you. So we ask Allah to guide you to the religion of Islam.

What do his words indicate? Do they indicate that whoever worships idols, the worship of al-Lāt and al-‘Uzzā and insults the religion of the Messenger, after having testified to it, such as Abū Jahl’s insulting it, is not declared a Kafir specifically?

Rather, the wording is explicit and clear regarding the disbelief of people such as Ibn Fīrūz, Ṣāliḥ ibn ‘Abd Allāh, and others like them manifest Kufr that expels one from the religion, let alone others.

This is explicit and clear in the words of Ibn al-Qayyim, and also in the words of the Shaykh whom you mentioned as having removed your difficulty concerning the Kufr of one who worships the idol that is over the grave of Yūsuf and others like it, and calls upon them in times of hardship and ease, and insults the religion of the Messenger after having acknowledged, testified to, and professed it, and after professing the worship of idols.

There is no exaggeration in what I have said. Rather, you yourself testify to this concerning them. But when Allah blinds the heart, there is no remedy for it.

What I fear for you is the saying of Allah تعالى:

‘That is because they believed, and then they disbelieved; so their hearts were sealed over, and they do not understand.’ [Qur’an 63:3]

The doubt that has entered you is because of this small amount of property that you possess. You fear that you and your children will become impoverished if you leave the land of the polytheists. You have doubts regarding Allah’s provision. Also, there are evil companions.

And you, may Allah protect us, are descending one degree at a time: first into doubt, then into the land of shirk, and then into loyalty toward them, and praying behind them.”

This concludes his words, may Allah تعالى have mercy upon him.

Consider carefully his statement regarding declaring these scholars to be Kuffar, and regarding the Kufr of one who worships the idol that is over the grave of Yūsuf. He states that this is explicit in the words of Ibn al-Qayyim, رحمه الله.

Also consider his account concerning the author of the letter and how he applied to him the verse concerning the hypocrites, and that this is a general ruling.

Then consider the situation today of many of those who claim to belong to religion and knowledge among the people of Najd. They travel to the lands of the Mushrikeen, remain there for a period seeking knowledge from them and sitting with them.

Then, when they return to the Muslims and are told:
“Fear Allah and repent to your Lord for this,”

they mock the person who says this to them and say:
“Repent from seeking knowledge?”

Then his actions and statements began to reveal what indicated the corruption and falsity of his beliefs. There is nothing surprising about this, because he disobeyed Allah and His Messenger by associating with the Mushrikeen, and was consequently punished for it.

What is surprising, however, is the attitude of the Ahl al Deen and tawhīd, because of their openness and association with this group who sought to place the Mushrikeen and Muwahhideen on the same level, whereas Allah has distinguished between them in His Book and through the tongue of His Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ.

Then Shaykh Muḥammad رحمه الله said in that letter, after mentioning the many people who apostatized from Islam after the Prophet ﷺ, such as those during the time of Abū Bakr رضي الله عنه, whom they judged with apostasy because they refused to pay zakāh, as well as the followers of ‘Alī and Ahl Al masjid in Kūfah, and Banū ‘Ubayd al-Qaddāḥ:

“All of these were judged with apostasy as specific individuals.”

Then he said:

“As for the statement of Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah with which they have confused you, it is even more problematic than all of this. If we were to adopt it, we would declare many well-known individuals to be Kuffar specifically.

For he explicitly stated in it that a specific individual is not declared a Kafir unless the proof has been established against him.

But if a specific individual becomes a Kafir once the proof has been established against him, then it is known that establishing the proof does not mean that he must understand the words of Allah and His Messenger in the same way that Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq رضي الله عنه understood them.

Rather, if the words of Allah and His Messenger reach him, and he is free from anything that excuses him, then he is a Kafir, just as the Kuffar as a whole had the proof established against them through the Qur’an, despite the statement of Allah تعالى:

“Indeed, We have placed over their hearts coverings, lest they understand it.” [18:57]

“Indeed, the worst of living creatures in the sight of Allah are the deaf and dumb who do not use reason.” [8:22]

If the Shaykh’s statement was not concerning apostasy and shirk, but rather concerning subsidiary issues, then he further clarified this by saying:

“This is made clear by the fact that when the hypocrites openly manifested their hypocrisy, they became apostates. So where is your claim that he does not declare anyone a Kafir specifically?”

He also said in his discussion of the Mu’takallimeen and those like them, when he mentioned some of their A’immah committing various forms of apostasy and Kufr:

“And this, if it is concerning obscure statements, then it may be said that he is mistaken and misguided, and that the proof whose rejection constitutes Kufr has not been established against him. But this occurs among groups in matters that are manifest, which the Mushrikun, Jews, and Christians know that Muhammad ﷺ was sent with, and that those who opposed them were declared Kuffar, such as his command to worship Allah alone, without partner, and his prohibition of worshipping anyone besides Him, whether prophets, angels, or others. For this is among the most manifest symbols of Islam.

Yet you find many of their leading figures falling into these forms of Kufr, and thus they became Murtaddin. Many of them at times openly apostatized from Islam, until he said:

‘More serious than this is that among them were those who wrote books concerning apostasy, just as al-Rāzī wrote about the worship of the stars. This is apostasy from Islam according to the agreement of the Muslimeen.’

This is his exact wording.

So consider carefully his words concerning the distinction between hidden statements and the matter we are discussing regarding the Kufr of a specific individual.

Consider also his declaring their leading figures, so-and-so and so-and-so, to be Kuffar specifically, and declaring their apostasy to be an explicit apostasy.

And consider his explicit transmission of the consensus that Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī had apostatized from Islam, despite being one of the leading A'immaḥ of the Shāfi'iyyah.

Does this accord with the claim attributed to him that a specific individual is not declared a Kafir, even if he calls upon 'Abd al-Qādir in times of ease and hardship, or loves 'Abd Allāh ibn 'Awf and claims that his tomb is good while worshipping Abū Ḥadīda?

Shaykh al-Islām also said:

“Rather, every shirk in the world has only arisen from the opinions of people of their own kind. They are the ones who command shirk and practice it. Whoever among them does not command shirk does not prohibit it either; rather, he approves of both these groups. Even if he gives some preference to Muwahhideen, he has nevertheless given preference to the Mushrikeen in another respect. And he may turn away from both groups altogether.

So contemplate this, for it is extremely beneficial. Likewise, those who were within the religion of Islam but did not prohibit shirk or make tawḥīd obligatory, rather they permitted shirk and commanded it, when they claimed tawḥīd, their tawḥīd was only in speech, not in action.”

This concludes his words, رحمه الله.

So contemplate his words and compare them with the false understanding with which Satan has deceived you, through which you have denied Allah, His Messenger, and the consensus of the Ummah, and through which you have sided with the worship of the ṭāghūt.

If you understand this, then praise Allah. If you do not, then I advise you to increase in humble supplication and prayer to the One in Whose Hand is guidance, for the danger is immense.

Indeed, remaining eternally in the Fire as the recompense for explicit apostasy is not something worth exchanging for a small amount of worldly property, whether two tūmāns or half a tūmān.

And among us there are people who come with their families and do not even beg.

And Allah has said concerning this matter:

“O My servants who have believed, indeed My earth is spacious, so worship only Me.” [29:56]

“And how many a creature carries not its [own] provision. Allah provides for it and for you. And He is the Hearing, the Knowing.” [29:60]

This concludes the Shaykh’s words from the aforementioned letter, in his exact wording, with some abridgment.

Refer back to it in the historical source, for it is extremely beneficial.

The point is that the proof was established through the Messenger and the Qur’an. Thus, whoever heard of the Messenger and to whom the Qur’an reached, the proof had been established against him.

This is apparent in the words of Shaykh al-Islām when he said:

“For it is known that the establishment of the proof does not mean that he understands the words of Allah and His Messenger in the same way that Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq understood them. Rather, if the words of Allah and His Messenger reach him, and he is free from anything that could excuse him, then he is a Kafir, just as the Kuffar as a whole had the proof established against them through the Qur’an.”

This is despite the saying of Allah تعالى:

“Indeed, We have placed over their hearts coverings, lest they understand it, and in their ears deafness.” [18:57]

So contemplate his words, give them your full attention, and ask Allah for guidance.

These are three places in which he mentions that the proof has been established through the Qur’an against everyone to whom it has reached and who has heard it, even if he did not understand it. And praise be to Allah, every Muslim who has heard the Qur’an believes this. However, the Shayateen have led most people away from the natural disposition (fiṭrah) upon which Allah created His servants.

Then contemplate the words of Shaykh al-Islām concerning his ruling that they are Kuffar. Did he say, “They are not declared Kuffar until they are made to understand,” or “They are not called Mushrikeen; rather, their action is shirk,” as the person we referred to earlier said?

Then contemplate the Shaykh's account of Shaykh al-Islām's statement concerning the Mu'takallimeen and those like them:

"And this, if it is concerning obscure statements, then it may be said that he is mistaken and misguided, and that the proof whose rejection constitutes Kufr has not been established against him until he is made to understand. But this applies to matters that are manifest..."

until he said:

"The Jews, Christians, and Mushrikeen know that Muhammad was sent with them, and that whoever opposed them was declared a Kafir, such as his command to worship Allah alone, without partner, and his prohibition of worshipping anyone besides Him, whether prophets or angels."

Then you find that many of their leading figures fell into these forms of Kufr, and thus they became Murtaddin.

The Shaykh then said:

"So contemplate his words concerning the distinction between hidden statements and what we are discussing regarding the Kufr of a specific individual. And contemplate his declaring their leading figures to be Kuffar specifically."

So stop and contemplate, as the Shaykh said. This much is sufficient to refute this doubt.

Shaykh al-Islām, may Allah sanctify his soul, classified this among the manifest matters, to the extent that even the Jews and Christians know this to be part of the religion of Islam.

As for the person we have described to you, he is blind to this. Perhaps he reads these statements and even teaches them, but he is prevented from applying them to the actual people and circumstances around him.

There are several reasons for this. Among them is not fearing for oneself that one may deviate and turn away from the truth. The Salaf feared this.

It may also be that a person has a personal inclination that prevents him from recognizing the truth and extracting it from the texts, as Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb, may Allah have mercy upon him mentioned in one of his letters. The author of al-Tārīkh stated that he said:

“Among these things is that we may explain an issue concerning the Usul Al Deen to a student for an entire year. He understands it and forms a clear conception of it, but when it actually occurs, he does not understand it. Stop and contemplate.”

He also mentioned that one of the scholars of al-Washm explained tawḥīd in one of his correspondences to Shaykh Muḥammad and asked him whether he was correct or not. The Shaykh replied:

“Your explanation of tawḥīd is correct, and you have indeed got it right. But the real issue is what comes after knowledge: putting it into practice. For when some of the letters of the enemies of the religion, in which they insulted the religion and its people, arrived in your town, you went along with them, neither opposing them nor separating yourself from them.”

Or words to that effect.

So contemplate this, for if you escape from this, you will have escaped from a tremendous matter.

Consider also the Shaykh's words in applying the ruling to the author of the letter: that although the hypocrites sided with the worship of the ṭāghūt, he ruled that he had apostatized.

Among the greatest things the Shaykh mentioned about him was that he hesitated regarding declaring a specific individual a Kafir, and that what prevented him from migrating with his family was the merchandise he possessed and his fear of poverty.

Then look at the condition of those whom we have mentioned and those like them in their journeys to the lands of the Mushrikeen, their reading to them, and their seeking knowledge from them, as they claim.

They acknowledge this themselves, and it is something known about them. Otherwise, they are accused of loyalty toward them and inclination toward them.

Among the calamities is that when this type of person returns to the Muslims, they treat him with the same honor and greetings that they gave him before he went to the Mushrikeen.

At times, they even express praise for and admiration of the lands of the Mushrikeen while disparaging the Muslims and their lands, in a manner that clearly indicates that it can only arise from a corrupt inner disposition.

And they continue upon this, while only a few among them object to it.

As for anyone fearing that they might apostate or deviate because of their actions, I do not think this even occurs to anyone's mind.

Thus, these are the religious rulings that are applied to someone who commits an act contrary to them.

Ruling on One Who Rejects What the Messenger ﷺ Brought After the Proof Has Been Established Against Him :—

As the Shaykh رحمه الله and Shaykh al-Islām رحمه الله before him mentioned regarding certain people who were present and then became manifest in their condition, as the propagator of those aforementioned well-known figures mentioned, look at your own condition and reflect upon what you believe. If you escape from this, then you will have escaped from a tremendous matter; otherwise, there is no cause for surprise. And there is no might and no power except with Allah.

Among the evidence for our position is what the Shaykh رحمه الله تعالى wrote to 'Īsā ibn Qāsim and Aḥmad ibn Suwaylim, when they asked him about the statement of Shaykh al-Islām Taqī al-Dīn may Allah sanctify his soul:

“Whoever rejects what the Messenger brought, after the proof has been established against him, is a Kafir.”

He replied:

“To the two brothers, 'Īsā ibn Qāsim and Aḥmad ibn Suwaylim: Peace, mercy, and blessings of Allah be upon you.

As for what you have mentioned from the words of the Shaykh, ‘Whoever rejects such-and-such and such-and-such’ and your asking whether the proof has been established against these ṭawāghīt and their followers or not, this is truly astonishing!

How can you have doubts about this when I have explained to you repeatedly that the one against whom the proof has not been established is the person who is newly entered into Islam, or one who grew up in a remote desert, or when the matter concerns hidden issues, such as al-ṣarf and al-ʿaṭf; such a person is not declared a Kafir until the matter has been explained to him.

As for the Usul Al Deen, that Allah has clarified in His Book, then Allah's proof is the Qur'an. Whoever the Qur'an reaches has received the proof.

But the foundational (Asl) source of the confusion is that you have not distinguished between the establishment of the proof and the understanding of the proof.

For most of the Kuffar and Munafiqeen did not understand Allah's proof, despite the fact that it had been established against them, as Allah تعالى said: "Or do you think that most of them hear or reason? They are not except like livestock. Rather, they are [even] more astray in [their] way." [25:44]

The establishment and reaching of the proof is one matter, while their understanding of it is another matter. So contemplate the words of the Shaykh, and we ask Allah to grant you correct understanding and to protect you from fanaticism.

Consider the Shaykh's statement that everyone to whom the Qur'an has reached has had the proof established against him, even if he did not understand it. He made this the reason for the error of those who went wrong, because they made ta'rīf (explaining the proof to someone) applicable to matters that are hidden, whereas the person whom we have mentioned made ta'rīf applicable to the Usul Al Deen.

And after the Qur'an and the Messenger, what further ta'rīf is there? Then he says: "This is our belief and the belief of our shaykhs."

We seek refuge in Allah from turning back after having advanced.

This issue occurs very frequently throughout the writings of Shaykh Muḥammad رحمه الله because the polytheistic scholars of his time disputed with him regarding declaring a specific individual a Kafir.

For example, this is the case with his commentary on the ḥadīth of 'Amr ibn 'Abasah. From beginning to end, it deals with declaring a specific individual a Kafir. Indeed, he even quotes Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah رحمه الله as saying:

"Whoever calls upon 'Alī has disbelieved, and whoever does not declare him a Kafir has disbelieved."

Reflect carefully upon the proofs that the Shaykh included in it. If a rational and impartial person reflects upon them, let alone a believer, he will recognize that this issue is one upon which there is agreement, and that it only becomes confusing to someone whose belief has been corrupted.

Shaykh Sulaymān ibn 'Abd Allāh رحمه الله تعالى mentioned in several places in his Sharh on Kitāb al-Tawḥīd that if someone pronounces the statement of tawḥīd, prays, and pays zakāh, but contradicts that through his actions and statements by calling upon the righteous, seeking their aid, and slaughtering sacrifices for them, then he resembles the Jews and Christians in their pronouncing the statement of tawḥīd while contradicting it.

Therefore, according to the position of the person who says that the Mushrikeen must first be given an explanation, he would also have to say that the Jews and Christians must first be given an explanation, and that they cannot be declared disbelievers until after that explanation.

This conclusion is very clear when considered carefully.

As for the writings of Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf ibn ‘Abd al-Raḥmān رحمه الله تعالى concerning this issue, they are very numerous. We shall mention only a small portion because this is an issue upon which there is agreement, and the present discussion is intended to be brief.

So we will mention from his words something that will alert you to the doubts used as evidence by those whom we have mentioned concerning the person who worshipped the dome of al-Kawwāz, and the claim that the Shaykh refrained from declaring him a Kafir.

Otherwise, the incident itself is merely a claim, and a claim cannot serve as proof. Rather, it requires evidence and testimony from the Qur’an and Sunnah.

The one whom Allah has granted insight, and whom He has protected from fanaticism, and who has carefully studied this issue, will find that he affirmed the Kufr of the specific individual throughout his writings and did not hesitate concerning any of them.

Now let us return to the context of the response that we referred to.

Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf رحمه الله said concerning the statement of al-‘Irāqī, “You have declared the people of Harmayn and their inhabitants to be Kuffar.”

He mentioned his words and responded to them, until he said:

Al-‘Irāqī said:

“It is well known that refraining from declaring Muslims who have spoken about this subject to be Kuffar, even if they are mistaken, is among the most legitimate objectives. If a person exercises ijtihād, he receives two rewards if he is correct, and one reward if he is mistaken.”

End of al-‘Irāqī’s statement.

The response is that it should be said:

This statement is of the same kind of distortion that we have already established. For it contains two distortions.

The first is that he omitted the question and presented it as though it concerned takfīr in matters over which there was dispute and disagreement between Ahl al-Sunnah wa-l-Jamā‘ah, the Khawārij, and the Rāfiḍah.

They declared Muslims and Ahl al-Sunnah to be Kuffar merely because they opposed them regarding bid’ah and principles that they themselves introduced, established, and adopted.

He omitted this because he feared that it would be said:

Calling upon the people of the graves, asking them, and seeking their aid is not of this category.

Rather, the Muslims did not dispute concerning these matters. They agreed that they constitute shirk that entails Kufr, as Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah related, and he classified them among the matters concerning which there is no disagreement regarding takfīr.

Therefore, it is not correct to interpret his statement here as referring to something which he himself firmly declared to be Kufr upon which there was Ijma.

And even if al-‘Irāqī’s interpretation were accepted, his statement would then be contradictory. But Allah protected and preserved him from such a thing.

Rather, his statements are consistent with one another, and each part confirms the other.

Once you understand this, you will understand the distortion committed by al-‘Irāqī through omitting and deleting part of the original statement.

Furthermore, removing words from the original statement changes its intended meaning and removes it from its proper context and intended purpose.

The second distortion is that the Shaykh رحمه الله said: “The Asl concerns Takfir Al Muslimeen.” But the Shaykh’s statements exclude the grave-worshippers from being considered among the Muslims, as we shall quote from his words concerning the ruling upon them, in which he states that they do not fall under the designation of Muslims in matters such as this.

He mentioned some discussion concerning Muslims who make mistakes in certain subsidiary matters, until he said:

“Whoever believes concerning a human being that he is a deity, or calls upon a dead person and asks him for provision, victory, or guidance, relies upon him, and prostrates to him, such a person is asked to repent. If he repents, he is released; otherwise, his neck is struck.”

End of quote.

Thus, al-‘Irāqī’s argument is invalid and collapses from its foundation. How can the prohibition against Takfir Al Muslimeen be applied to someone who calls upon the righteous, seeks their aid alongside Allah, and directs toward them acts of worship that are due exclusively to Allah?

This is invalid according to the texts of the Qur’an and Sunnah and the consensus of the scholars of the Muslim Ummah.

Among the astonishing aspects of al-‘Irāqī’s ignorance is that he uses the very claim under dispute as evidence against his opponent. But a claim cannot serve as proof.

Al-‘Irāqī’s claim that the grave-worshippers are Muslims itself requires decisive evidence establishing their Islam. Once their Islam is established, then declaring them Kuffar would indeed be prohibited. The subsequent reasoning is not difficult.

It is known that whoever declares Muslims to be Kuffar merely because of his personal desires, like the Khawārij and Rāfiḍah, or declares someone a Kafir because he has erred in matters of ijtihād, whether fundamental or subsidiary, is a Muḩtadi and misguided, opposing the way of the A’immah of guidance and the scholars of the religion.

A figure such as Shaykh Muḩammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb does not declare people Kuffar on account of this category, nor does he declare them Kuffar merely for being of this type.

Rather, he declares Kuffar those whom the Noble Qur’an explicitly declares Kuffar, whom the authentic Sunnah declares Kuffar, and whose Kufr the Ummah has agreed upon, such as one who changes his religion and performs the acts of the people of Jahiliyyah who worshipped prophets, angels, and righteous people and called upon them.

Allah declared them Kuffar and permitted their lives, wealth, and offspring to be taken because they worshipped other than Him whether a prophet, a saint, or an idol. There is no difference between them regarding the ruling of Kufr, as demonstrated by the Noble Qur'an and widely transmitted Sunnah.

A detailed explanation of this will come to you later, and some of it has already been mentioned.

He also said:

“He was asked about people such as these ignorant ones, and he explained that whoever has had the proof established against him and is capable of understanding it is declared a Kafir for worshipping graves. As for the one who is attached to the earth and follows his desires, I do not know what his condition is.”

What has already been quoted from his words contains sufficient clarification.

Furthermore, Al Allamah Ibn al-Qayyim رحمه الله firmly declared the imitators of their Mashayikh to be Kuffar in matters whose rejection constitutes Kufr, provided that they were capable of seeking and knowing the truth and were qualified to do so, yet deliberately turned away from it and paid no attention to it.

As for the one who was unable and not qualified to know what the Messengers brought, then according to him, such a person belongs to the category of Ahl al-Fatrah, those to whom the call of a messenger did not reach.

Neither of these two categories is ruled to be Muslim, nor are they included under the designation of Muslimeen.

Even according to those who did not declare some of them to be Kuffar. You will come across his words on this later.

As for shirk, it certainly applies to them, and its designation encompasses them. And what Islam remains with someone who contradicts its very foundation and greatest principle: the testimony that there is no deity worthy of worship except Allah?

The continuation of Islam and its designation even with some of the matters mentioned by the fuqaha in the chapter on Hukm Al Murtad is more conceivable than its continuation alongside the worship and supplication of the righteous.

But al-‘Irāqī flees from calling this worship and supplication, claiming that it is merely tawassul and calling upon them, and he considers it recommended.

How far! Where is there any escape?

The gods being sought have been rendered incapable of providing refuge by what Allah has bestowed through His Mighty Book, which falsehood cannot approach from before it or from behind it, a revelation from the All-Wise, Worthy of Praise and through what Muḥammad, His servant and Messenger, brought of wisdom, guidance, and clarification of the limits of what Allah revealed to him.

Allah سبحانه وتعالى continues to raise for this religion those through whom He establishes His proof against His servants, and who strive to clarify His religion and law, and to refute those who deviate from His Book and His religion and divert them from their proper meanings, and so on from what he mentioned.

So contemplate his statement, رحمه الله:

“Calling upon the occupants of graves, asking them, and seeking their aid is not part of this category. The Muslims did not dispute concerning it; rather, there is agreed upon that it is shirk that entails Kufr, as Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah himself related, and he classified it among those matters concerning which there is no disagreement regarding takfīr. It is therefore not correct to interpret his statement here as referring to something which he himself decisively declared to be disbelief.”

**I say: This is further demonstrated by his earlier statement:
“Whoever calls upon ‘Alī has disbelieved...”**

Then he said:

“The second distortion is what he said concerning the fundamental principle (Asl) that the issue of takfīr of Muslimeen, whereas the Shaykh’s statements excluded the grave-worshippers from the designation of Muslims.”

So contemplate his first and second statements: this is something upon which is agreed upon, that the grave-worshippers are not Muslims and are not included within the designation of Islam. And this is precisely the statement of Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah.

He continued:

“He is asked to repent; if he repents, then he is spared, and if not, he is killed by striking his neck.”

He did not say, “He must first be made to understand,” nor did he say, “He is not declared a Kafir until he is made to understand,” as was imagined by someone who has no knowledge or whose fundamental understanding of the religion has been corrupted.

Then consider his response to al-‘Irāqī, where he said:

“Thus al-‘Irāqī’s argument is invalid and collapses from its foundation. How can the prohibition against declaring Muslims to be Kuffar apply to someone who calls upon the righteous and seeks their aid?”

He said:

“This is invalid according to the Qur’an, the Sunnah, and the Ijma of the scholars of the Ummah.”

Until he said:

“Rather, Shaykh Muḥammad only declares Kuffar those whom the Qur’an and Sunnah declare to be Kuffar and whose Kufr the Ummah has unanimously agreed upon, such as one who changes his religion and performs the acts of Jahiliyyah who worshipped angels, prophets, and righteous people and called upon them. Allah declared them Kuffar and permitted their lives, wealth, and offspring to be taken because of their worship of other than Him, whether a prophet, a saint, or an idol. There is no difference between them regarding Kufr, as demonstrated by the Noble Qur’an.”

End of his words.

I say: This is among the clearest things explaining the answer concerning his statement about the ignorant man who worshipped the dome of al-Kawwāz, because he did not make an exception there for an ignorant person or anyone else.

This is the method of the Qur’an: declaring whoever commits shirk to be a Kafir in general terms.

His hesitation in some of his answers should therefore be understood as having resulted from some particular circumstance.

Furthermore, as you can see, he hesitated on one occasion, as in his statement:

“As for the one who is attached to the earth, I do not know what his condition is.”

So, by Allah, how astonishing! How can the Shaykh’s statements throughout all these other places, together with the evidence of the Qur’an and Sunnah and the statements of Shaykh al-Islām and Ibn al-Qayyim, such as his statement that whoever the Qur’an reaches has had the proof established against him be abandoned, while one accepts a single statement that is general and ambiguous?

Also pay attention to what Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf transmitted from Ibn al-Qayyim: that the least that can be said about such people is that they are like Ahl Al Fatrah who perished before the sending of the Messenger, or those to whom the call of any prophet did not reach.

He continued:

“Neither of these two categories is judged to be Muslim, nor are they included within the designation of Muslims even according to those who did not declare some of them to be Kuffar. As for shirk, it certainly applies to them, and its designation encompasses them. And what Islam remains when its foundation and greatest principle, the testimony that there is no deity worthy of worship except Allah is contradicted?”

Let us now mention a statement of Ibn al-Qayyim that he included in his discussion of the categories of those legally accountable, which Shaykh ‘Abd al-Laṭīf quoted in his refutation of al-‘Irāqī. It will serve as an explanation of what we have already mentioned and will remove the remaining traces of this doubt from you.

Ibn al-Qayyim رحمه الله said in his book Ṭabaqāt al-Mukallafīn, when discussing the leading Kuffar who hindered people from the path of Allah and that their punishment would be multiplied:

“The seventeenth category: the category of the blind imitators, the ignorant among the Kuffar, and their followers and imitators who merely follow them, saying, ‘Indeed, we found our forefathers upon a way, and we follow their example.’

Along with this, they are peaceful toward the Muslims and do not fight them, such as the wives of combatant Kuffar, their servants, and their followers who did not set themselves up for what those others set themselves up for namely, striving to extinguish the light of Allah, destroy His religion, and suppress His words. Rather, they are like beasts.

The Ummah has agreed that this category consists of Kuffar, even though they are ignorant and merely imitate their leaders and A’immah.

The only exception is what is reported from some Ahl Al Bid’ah, who did not rule that these people would be in the Fire, but placed them in the position of those to whom the call did not reach.

This is a position that none of the A’immah of Muslimeen held, not the Sahabah, nor the Tābi’ūn, nor those who came after them. Rather, it is only known from some of the later theological innovators who introduced such views into Islam.

It is authentically reported from the Prophet ﷺ that he said: ‘There is no child who is born except that he is born upon the fiṭrah; then his parents make him a Jew, a Christian, or a Magian.’

Thus, he informed us that the parents move the child away from the fiṭrah to Judaism, Christianity, or Magianism, and he did not consider anything other than the upbringing and environment upon which the parents raise him.

And it is authentically reported from him عليه السلام that he said: ‘Paradise will not be entered except by a Muslim soul.’

This imitator is not a Muslim, yet he is rational and legally accountable. A rational person cannot be outside one of two categories: Islam or Kufr.

As for the one to whom the call did not reach, then he is not legally accountable in that state. He is like children and the insane. We have already discussed them.”

I say: This category namely, those to whom the call did not reach, is the category that Shaykh al-Islām Ibn Taymiyyah excluded in what al-‘Irāqī quoted, and it is also the category that our Shaykh Muḥammad ibn ‘Abd al-Wahhāb رحمه الله تعالى excluded.

Islam is to single out Allah in worship, worship Him alone without partner, believe in His Messenger, and follow him in what he brought. Whoever does not bring these things is not a Muslim.

Even if he is not a stubborn Kafir, he is a disbelieving ignoramus. Thus, the furthest that can be said regarding this category is that they are ignorant Kafir who are not obstinate.

Their lack of obstinacy does not remove them from being Kuffar. For a Kafir is one who rejects the Tawḥīd of Allah تعالى and denies His Messenger, either out of obstinacy or out of ignorance and imitation of the people of obstinacy.

Although such a person may ultimately be non-obstinate, he is nevertheless following the people of obstinacy.

Allah تعالى has informed us in the Qur'an, in more than one place, of the punishment of those who imitate their predecessors among the Kuffar, that the followers will be with those whom they followed, and that they will dispute with one another in the Fire.

He then mentioned verses and ahadith concerning this, and said: "This indicates that the Kufr of those who followed them was merely due to their following and imitating them."

Yes, however, this matter requires some detailed clarification, through which the confusion can be removed. There is a distinction between:

- 1. An imitator who had the ability to acquire knowledge and recognize the truth, but turned away from it.**
- 2. An imitator who was in no way capable of doing so.**

Both categories exist in reality.

The first, the one who had the ability but turned away, is negligent and has abandoned what was obligatory upon him, and he has no excuse before Allah.

As for the one who is incapable of asking and acquiring knowledge, and who has no means whatsoever of obtaining knowledge, they are of two types:

The first: A person who desires guidance, prefers it, and loves it, but is unable to attain it or seek it because there is no one to guide him. His ruling is the ruling of Ahl al-Fatrah and those to whom the call did not reach.

The second: A person who turns away from desiring guidance and does not even consider anything other than what he is upon.

The first says:

“My Lord, if I knew of a religion better than what I am upon, I would follow it and abandon what I am upon. But I know nothing except what I am upon, and I am incapable of anything else. This is the extent of my effort and the limit of my knowledge.”

The second is content with what he is upon. He does not prefer anything else over it, nor does he desire anything other than it. To him, there is no difference between a state in which he is incapable and a state in which he has the ability.

Both are incapable, but the second should not be placed in the same category as the first, because of the difference between them.

The first is like someone who sought the true religion during a period in which the message had ceased, but failed to find it. After exhausting his efforts in seeking it, he abandoned the search due to inability and ignorance.

The second is like someone who did not seek it at all, but died upon his shirk even though, had he sought it, he would have been unable to attain it.

Therefore, distinguish between the inability of the one who seeks and the inability of the one who turns away from seeking.

Allah will judge between His servants on the Day of Resurrection with His justice and wisdom, and He will not punish anyone except one against whom the proof has been established through the Messengers. This is certain with regard to mankind in general.

As for whether the proof was established against Zayd specifically or ‘Amr specifically, this is something that cannot be entered into between Allah and His servants. Rather, it is obligatory upon the servant to believe that whoever follows a religion other than Islam is a Kafir, and that Allah تعالى does not punish anyone until the proof has been established against him through the Messenger. This is in general terms; as for determining specific individuals, that is entrusted to Allah’s knowledge and judgment.

This concerns the rulings of reward and punishment. As for the rulings of this world, they are based upon what is outwardly apparent. Thus, the children and insane of the Kuffar are considered Kuffar according to the rulings of this world, and they have the ruling of their guardians.

Through this distinction, the difficulty in this issue is removed. It is based upon four principles.

The first: Allah سبحانه وتعالى does not punish anyone until the proof has been established against him, as He تعالى says:

**“And never would We punish until We sent a messenger.”
[Qur’an 17:15]**

And He says:

**“[We sent] messengers as bringers of good tidings and warners so that mankind will have no argument against Allah after the messengers.”
[Qur’an 4:165]**

He then mentioned several other verses.

Then he said:

“And Allah تعالى says: ‘And We did not wrong them, but it was they who were the wrongdoers.’”

[Qur'an 43:76]

The wrongdoer is one who knew what the Messenger ﷺ brought, or was capable of knowing it, and then opposed it and turned away from it.

As for one who had no knowledge whatsoever of the Messenger, nor any means of knowing him, and was incapable of doing so, then how can he be called a wrongdoer?

The second: Punishment becomes deserved for two reasons.

The first is turning away from the proof, not desiring it or what it requires.

The second is obstinately opposing it after it has been established and refusing what it requires.

The first is disbelief through turning away (kufr al-i'rāḍ), while the second is disbelief through obstinacy (kufr al-'inād).

As for disbelief through ignorance, when the proof has not been established and the person has no ability to know it, this is what Allah has negated punishment for until His proof is established through the Messengers.

The third: The establishment of the proof differs according to times, places, and individuals.

Allah's proof may be established against Kuffar in one period but not another, and in one region or locality but not another. Likewise, it may be established against one person but not another either because the person lacks intellect and discernment, such as a child or an insane person, or because he is unable to understand, such as someone who cannot comprehend and has no interpreter present to translate for him.

Such a person is like the deaf person who cannot hear anything and has no ability to understand. He is one of the four who will present their argument before Allah on the Day of Resurrection, as mentioned previously in the ḥadīth of al-Aswad, Abū Hurayrah, and others.

Then the Shaykh رحمه الله said:

“Stop here and contemplate this remarkable clarification. For he only made an exception for the one who was incapable of recognizing the truth despite intensely seeking it and desiring it. This category is what is intended in the statements of Shaykh al-Islām, Ibn al-Qayyim, and others among the verifying scholars.

As for al-‘Irāqī and his fellow false claimants, they created the doubt that the Shaykh does not declare the ignorant person a Kafir and that he considers him excused. They spoke generally without providing detail, and made this doubt a shield with which they repel the Qur’anic verses and Prophetic ḥadīths. They raised their voices against the servants of Allah who affirm tawḥīd, just as their predecessors among the grave-worshippers and Mushrikeen had done.

And to Allah is the return, and He is the Judge between His servants concerning that over which they differed.”

This concludes what the Shaykh رحمه الله mentioned.

So contemplate this if you are someone who seeks the truth through its evidence. But if you are someone who has firmly committed himself to falsehood and wishes to support it by relying upon generalized statements from the scholars, then there is nothing surprising in that.

And may Allah send peace and blessings upon Muḥammad, the unlettered Prophet, and upon his family and all his Companions.

Dhū al-Ḥijjah, 1312 AH

Copied from the handwriting of the author himself, may Allah تعالى have mercy upon him. May Allah reward him on behalf of Islam and the Muslims with the best of rewards.

Written by the one who is poor and in need of Allah تعالى: His servant, the son of His servant and the son of His maidservant, ‘Abd al-‘Azīz al-Fawzān, may Allah forgive him, his parents, his teachers, and all the Muslims and their Imams through whom Allah preserved the religion and humbled the people of deviation at all times.

And may Allah send abundant peace and blessings upon the master of the Messengers, our Prophet Muḥammad, and upon his family and Companions, until the Day of Judgment.

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

From Ishāq ibn ‘Abd al-Raḥmān to whoever among the brothers sees this, and to all the leaders on the coast of Oman, and those among the people of Persia and Julān who are affiliated with the Sunnah and Imaan:

سلام عليكم ورحمة الله وبركاته

To proceed:

Indeed, Allah تعالى has obligated us to cooperate in righteousness and piety, and to support one another for His sake against the enemies. Every person has a share of servitude according to his capacity. Thus, wherever there is no excuse for refusing the truth, there is likewise no excuse for failing to convey it.

Some of the brothers had previously indicated their request for advice. What cannot all be attained should not all be abandoned. For this reason, I advise you and myself to fear Allah تعالى.

Taqwā is a comprehensive word encompassing the qualities of goodness, both in what is commanded and what is prohibited. Among its most difficult aspects is showing enmity toward whoever opposes Allah and His Messenger, denies His Names and Attributes, or associates partners with Him in His Tawḥīd.

You know that the purpose behind creation and the command is that Allah be known through His Names and Attributes, that He alone سبحانه be intended through all forms of worship, and that no one whatsoever be associated with Him.

And that people establish justice. Therefore, He sent down iron as an instrument through which those who depart from justice may be fought.

At the beginning of this century, the banner of Tawḥīd became apparent, and the swords of jihād were sheathed upon the heads of those who opposed it from the factions of disbelief and those who associated partners with Allah.

The prescribed legal punishments were established throughout the lands of the Muslims, and the obligations of the religion were fully upheld. This is something that cannot be hidden.

Our predecessors and your predecessors cooperated in this to such an extent that Allah humbled the enemies, until your lands became a stronghold of Islam and a place of migration for eminent leaders.

The callers to the truth have continued to exist in those regions, those who proclaim the realization of the Tawḥīd of the Messengers, guide the confused and ignorant through it, and reject the doctrines of the innovating Jahmiyyah who deny the Names of the Lord of the worlds.

Yet this fundamental principle became confused for many people until it was nearly erased, and its foundations were uprooted, except for whatever Allah willed.

Criticism of the Islamic call and the ḥanīfiyyah Muḥammadiyyah became widespread. It was proclaimed among the common people that whoever speaks the two testimonies is one of the people of Islam, while they failed to understand the purpose for which the testimony was prescribed: sincerely directing worship to Allah and disbelieving in whatever is worshipped besides Allah.

And a call was made for peaceful coexistence with those who cling to illusions, deny the religion, and oppose the Muslims, a blind, deaf, and dark call, whose proponents seek to extinguish what has become manifest of this firmly established religion.

But Allah refuses except to complete His light and exalt His Word.

A Warning Against Allegiance to the Enemies of Allah :—

During that period of division, we were tested by the nations converging against us, as a punishment for our turning away from this matter.

In the ḥadīth narrated from Thawbān رضي الله عنه, the Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“It is soon that the nations will summon one another against you, just as those eating invite one another to their dish.”

Someone asked, “Will that be because we are few at that time?”

He ﷺ said:

“Rather, you will be numerous at that time, but you will be like the foam carried by a flood. Allah will remove fear of you from the hearts of your enemies and will cast wahn into your hearts.”

Someone asked, “O Messenger of Allah, what is wahn?”

He ﷺ said:

“Love of this world and hatred of death.”

The ḥadīth therefore indicates that desiring this world and turning away from the Hereafter are causes of destruction, ruin, the domination of enemies, and the failure of one’s efforts.

It is also narrated from Thawbān, as a marfū‘ report, that the Prophet ﷺ said:

“The Hour will not be established until tribes of my Ummah join the Mushrikeen, and until groups of my Ummah worship idols.”

The tribulation involving them has grown widespread, the matter has become grave, and its evil has begun to affect the beliefs and faith of the Muslimeen.

Those who had no insight, no firm grounding, and no knowledge of the truth joined them. They thought that by adhering to some of the pillars of Islam while abandoning this greatest pillar, they were upon the straight path.

But this is not the case.

Rather, it is as Abū al-Wafā' ibn 'Aqīl رحمه الله said:

“If you wish to know the true state of Islam among the people of your time, do not look at their crowds at the doors of the mosques, nor at the loudness of their cries of ‘Labbayk.’ Rather, look at their alignment with the enemies of the Sharī‘ah.”

So hasten, hasten to the fortress of the religion, hold firmly to the strong rope of Allah, and align yourselves with His believing allies. Beware, beware of His opposing enemies.

Among the greatest acts by which one draws near to Allah تعالى is detesting whoever opposes Allah and His Messenger, and striving against him with the hand, tongue, and heart, according to one's ability. This is among the things that save a servant from the Fire.

Whoever has Allah and His Messenger more beloved to him than anything else must necessarily submit to the commands of the Qur'an and Sunnah and disavow every belief that contradicts what the righteous Salaf, the foremost of this Ummah were upon.

Has Islam ever been diminished, its rulings changed, and matters introduced into the religion that the All-Knowing King did not permit, except through callers standing at the gates of Hell, who turn people away from their religion?

So fear Allah, O servants of Allah, and do not allow this worldly life to carry you away completely, for it is the root of every sin.

By Allah, from its beginning to its end, this world is not a substitute even for a speck of the specks of the Hereafter.

And whenever someone who claims to be a Muslim turns away from this matter, allies himself with the Mushrikeen, attacks the Muslims, hastens toward comfort, becomes pleased with himself, and beautifies such conduct, that itself is the very cause of punishment, the reason for being forsaken, and the path to regret and humiliation.

Allah تعالى says:

“And those who disbelieved are allies of one another. If you do not do so, there will be fitnah on earth and great corruption.”

[Qur'an 8:73]

So how can someone who believes in Allah and the Last Day and fears a bad reckoning become attached to this worldly life, befriend the enemies, and forget the covenants of protection?

Allah تعالى says:

“O you who have believed, do not take the Jews and the Christians as allies. They are [in fact] allies of one another. And whoever is an ally to them among you – then indeed, he is [one] of them. Indeed, Allah guides not the wrongdoing people.”

[Qur'an 5:51]

Hudhayfah رضي الله عنه said:

“Let each of you beware of becoming a Jew or a Christian without realizing it.”

Then he recited this verse.

And ‘Umar رضي الله عنه reprimanded Abū Mūsā for appointing a Christian as a scribe. He said:

“May Allah kill you! Could you not have appointed a ḥanīf, a Muslim?”

And he recited this verse.

This was merely regarding employing him, so what about showing him loyalty and honoring him?

Allah تعالى has negated faith from the one who befriends the Mushrikeen. He says:

**“You will not find a people who believe in Allah and the Last Day having affection for those who oppose Allah and His Messenger...”
[Qur’an 58:22]**

It is known that whoever befriends someone is pleased with him. And when he is pleased with him, he becomes pleased with his religion, thereby becoming one of the people of his religion without realizing it.

Most people are alert to sin and its means, but they are not alert to shirk and its means.

When Allah prohibited taking His enemies among the disbelievers and polytheists as allies, while permitting dissimulation (taqiyyah) under compulsion, He said:

**“And Allah warns you of Himself.”
[Qur’an 3:28]**

This is among the greatest warnings and threats for whoever contemplates the Book of Allah and understands Allah’s command.

Yes, the seriousness of the people of other religions has become apparent to us after we witnessed people penetrating the ranks of the religion, intending to steal away the beliefs of the Muslims and introducing doubts through which they sought to turn people away from the clear and evident truth, whether from a malicious person from al-Aḥsā’ or a misleading Persian.

So draw closer to Allah تعالى by distancing yourselves from those who spread doubts, and seek knowledge of Tawhīd with its proofs and clear evidences.

One of the Salaf said:

“Allah loves penetrating insight when doubts arise, and sound intellect when desires arise.”

“and obey Allah and His Messenger, if you should be believers.”

[Qur'an 8:1]

And accept the sincere advice of one who is concerned for the Muslims.

Among the Causes of the Ummah's Salvation: Commanding Good and Forbidding Evil :—

There is another important matter here: bringing about blessings and preventing calamities from descending. This can only be achieved through commanding what is good, forbidding what is evil, and restraining the foolish person from wrongdoing.

Allah has condemned those among whom there were not enough people who would forbid corruption in the land. He تعالى says:

“So why were there not among the generations before you those of enduring discrimination forbidding corruption on earth – except a few of those We saved from among them? But those who wronged pursued what luxury they were given therein, and they were criminals.”

[Qur'an 11:116]

And He تعالى says:

“We saved those who had forbidden evil and seized those who wronged, with a wretched punishment.”

[Qur'an 7:165]

And He تعالى says:

“And let there be [arising] from you a nation inviting to [all that is] good, enjoining what is right and forbidding what is wrong, and those will be the successful.”

[Qur'an 3:104]

These verses demonstrate the obligation of commanding good and forbidding evil, and that there is no salvation except for those who undertake this duty.

They also demonstrate that following desires and preferring pleasures necessarily results in being among the criminals.

The verses and ahadith concerning this meaning are too numerous to enumerate.

Whoever has Allah alone as his purpose, object of worship, and beloved will submit to His commands and prohibitions and will not compromise concerning Him for anyone.

May Allah grant us and you success in being grateful for Allah's blessings, remaining patient in obedience to Him, avoiding that which brings about His anger and punishment, striving against the soul in opposing His enemies and loving His beloved servants.

And may Allah send abundant peace and blessings upon His servant and Messenger, the trustee of His revelation and the chosen one among His creation, Muḥammad, and upon his family and Companions, until the Day of Judgment.

Some Rulings Concerning the Legislated Boycott (Hijr) :—

He was asked about boycotting (hijr) and its details, and he replied: The legislated boycott is established by evidence, and many of the Salaf indicated it. It has different levels and circumstances, and it applies to the heart, tongue, and limbs.

Allah تعالى says concerning (Ibrāhīm) Khalil عليه السلام:

“And I will leave you and those you invoke other than Allah and will invoke my Lord.”

[Qur'an 19:48]

And Allah تعالى says concerning the People of the Cave:

“And when you have withdrawn from them and that which they worship other than Allah...”

[Qur'an 18:16]

The Prophet ﷺ also boycotted the three Companions, and their story is well known. Ibn al-Qayyim رحمه الله mentioned in Zād al-Ma'ād enough discussion of the jurisprudential lessons of their story.

The basic meaning of hijr is abandonment, separation, and hatred. In the Sharī'ah, it means abandoning what Allah has prohibited, keeping away from it, and distancing oneself from it.

It applies generally to both actions and people.

With regard to the Mushrikeen and those who associate themselves with them, approve of what they are upon, serve them, and look down upon the people of Islam, the ruling of boycott is even more emphatic, because the ugliness of a matter is determined by the ugliness of what it is connected to.

This broad principle has several categories and detailed rulings. Among them is boycotting the Kuffar and Mushrikeen. The Qur'an, from beginning to end, repeatedly calls toward this. One of its benefits is to distinguish the allies of Allah from His enemies.

Closely related to this is boycotting Ahl Al Bid'ah and Ahwa (desires). Imām Aḥmad and other scholars among the Salaf explicitly instructed people to keep away from them, avoid them, and refrain from offering the funeral prayer over them.

They said concerning Ahl Al Bid'ah::

“If they become ill, do not visit them; and if they die, do not attend their funerals.”

Thus, one must separate from them in the heart, with the tongue, and physically, except for someone who undertakes the religious duty of calling them to the truth and striving against them through evidence, provided that he is safe from causing greater discord and harm.

Allah تعالى says:

“And it has already come down to you in the Book that when you hear the verses of Allah [recited], they are denied [by them] and ridiculed; so do not sit with them...”

[Qur'an 4:140]

There are many verses, ahadith, and statements of the scholars concerning this matter.

Some of the scholars who thoroughly investigated the matter said: It is sufficient for a rational person to consider the statement of Allah تعالى, after He prohibited taking the Mushrikeen as allies:

“The Day every soul will find what it has done of good present [before it] and what it has done of evil, it will wish that between itself and that [evil] was a great distance. And Allah warns you of Himself.”

[Qur'an 3:30]

Ibn Kathīr رحمه الله تعالى has related a Ijma that the one who abandons migration is sinful and has committed something prohibited by abandoning the migration.

It is not sufficient merely to hate them in the heart. Rather, enmity and hatred must be outwardly manifested.

Allah تعالى says:

“There has already been for you an excellent pattern in Abraham and those with him, when they said to their people, “Indeed, we are disassociated from you and from whatever you worship other than Allah. We have denied you, and there has appeared between us and you animosity and hatred forever until you believe in Allah alone””

[Qur'an 60:4]

Consider this explanation, beyond which there is no further clarification, where Allah says:

“and there has appeared between us...”

Meaning: it became manifest and apparent.

This is the outward manifestation of the religion. Therefore, enmity must be openly declared, their disbelief openly stated, and there must be physical separation from them.

The meaning of enmity is that we are on one side and the opposing party is on another.

The foundation of disavowal (barā'ah) is separation through the heart, tongue, and body. The heart of a believer cannot be free of enmity toward a disbeliever. The disagreement concerns outwardly manifesting that enmity.

It may be concealed for a legitimate Sharī'ah reason, such as being compelled while the heart remains at ease with faith. It may also be concealed by a weak and oppressed person who has a valid excuse established by the Qur'an.

It may also be concealed for a worldly purpose, which is the more common situation among later generations—provided that he does not outwardly show agreement with them.

The claim of one whose insight Allah has blinded—that manifesting the religion merely means not preventing them from worshipping or studying—is a false claim. It is rejected both rationally and according to the Sharī'ah.

Those living in the lands of the Christians, Magians, and Hindus may rejoice at such a false ruling, because prayer, the adhān, and religious teaching already exist in their lands.

This would amount to abolishing migration and jihād and preventing people from the path of guidance.

The second category is a Muslim who grants himself concessions, prefers his worldly interests, and chooses to remain in their lands because of one of the eight recognized excuses.

Boycotting this category falls under the chapter of boycotting sinful people, which al-Bukhārī and others have discussed.

Such a person is not to be boycotted in the same manner as a disbeliever, because he retains rights as a Muslim, including advising him and supplicating for him.

However, we should not display toward him the same affection and friendliness shown toward those who believe and perform righteous deeds, to the extent that he sees no wrongdoing in his own conduct and others become deceived by him.

The Prophet ﷺ boycotted the three Companions despite their faith. ‘Umar also exiled Ṣubaygh to his homeland, ordered that he be boycotted, and prohibited people from speaking to him.

The Companions رضي الله عنهم continued to boycott people for matters even less serious than this.

There is an authentic ḥadīth narrated by Abū Dāwūd, al-Tirmidhī, al-Dāraquṭnī, and al-Ṭabarānī, from Jarīr ibn ‘Abd Allāh رضي الله عنه, that the Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“I am free of responsibility from any Muslim who resides among the Mushrikeen.”

Ibn Mājah also narrated it, and the men of its chain are trustworthy.

It also has supporting evidence in the marfū' ḥadīth of Mu'āwiyah ibn Ḥaydah:

“Allah does not accept from a Muslim any deed while he remains among the Mushrikeen...”

It was narrated by al-Nasā'ī.

There is also the ḥadīth of Samurah, narrated in marfū' form:

“Whoever associates with the polytheist...”

until the end of the ḥadīth, narrated by Abū Dāwūd.

The authenticity of these narrations is also supported by the statement of Allah تعالى:

“so do not sit with them until they enter into another conversation. Indeed, you would then be like them.”

[Qur'an 4:140]

Therefore, we disavow him, as the Messenger of Allah ﷺ did, and we keep away from him, whether the sinful person wishes it or not.

The Reviver of the Sunnah, al-Baghawī, mentioned some words that are appropriate to quote here. He said:

“As for boycotting the people of disobedience and the people of religious doubt, it is legislated until their condition becomes clear of doubt and their repentance becomes manifest.

Ka'b ibn Mālik said regarding his failure to participate in the expedition to Tabūk: the Messenger of Allah ﷺ prohibited people from speaking to us, and he mentioned that this lasted for fifty nights.

Muḥammad ibn Ismā'īl رحمه الله made the point at which the matter becomes clear to be the repentance of the sinner.

‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Umar said: ‘Do not greet those who drink wine.’

And Abū al-Dardā’ said:

‘You will never attain complete understanding until you detest people for the sake of Allah, then turn your attention to yourself and become even more severe in detesting yourself.’”

End of his words, رحمه الله .

The comprehensive principle underlying this is that recognizing that Allah تعالى سبحانه deserves to be worshipped, with fear, hope, awe, love, and veneration, leaves no room in a sound heart for love of His enemies or affection toward them.

Love is the foundation of every action, whether right or wrong. Thus, the foundation of religious actions is love of Allah and His Messenger, just as the foundation of religious statements is affirming the truthfulness of Allah and His Messenger.

But when love of this world became dominant over people, and they preferred it, they rejected this principle and forgot what they had previously been upon:

“and they disputed by [using] falsehood to [attempt to] invalidate thereby the truth.”

[Qur’an 40:5]

This was due to their ignorance of the true reality of Islam, its necessary implications, and its great principles.

Even if this matter contained nothing more than blocking the means leading to a reconciliation between the Muslim and the Mushrik, that alone would be sufficient.

However, because of widespread ignorance, little knowledge, and preferring worldly interests, some people who attributed themselves to Islam opened breaches in the fortress of Islam, preferring to please the common people.

If only these people had exercised as much caution concerning their religion as they exercised concerning their positions of leadership and their wealth!

How beautifully it has been said:

“You had been my support with which I struck,
and my hand when the enemy seized my arm.
I had hoped from you for the opposite of what I received;
yet a person may choke even on cool, pure water.”

As for those who travel to the lands of the Mushrikeen for trade, if they do not display loyalty, compromise, or friendliness toward the Mushrikeen and Murtaddin, then their condition is less serious than those mentioned previously.

Nevertheless, they share with them in the prohibition, although they differ in the degree of punishment, because residence may apply to a short or long period, and the ruling is connected in the texts to residence and association.

However, whenever the harm is reduced, the ruling is correspondingly reduced.

Indeed, sometimes the traveler may be worse than the resident.

We have witnessed among the sinful travelers from al-Qassim and elsewhere such an enormous number of grave evils that they cannot be counted: abandoning prayer, drinking intoxicants, beautifying the ways of the Mushrikeen, and attacking the people of religion. Because of this, Islam could scarcely be ascribed to most of them.

Indeed, even some people from al-Turk and certain inhabitants of Egypt would avoid the behavior of the sinful people of Najd.

There is no doubt that hating and detesting this category and feeling repelled by them is itself a genuine benefit.

Boycotting this type of person is not merely a recommended form of boycott; rather, it is obligatory, because the harm caused by them has become severe. They and those who grant them concessions among those who claim religious affiliation are a greater calamity than the distant enemy.

The general principle in this matter is:

To give preference to whatever leads to weakening and reducing evil, strengthening the truth, suppressing falsehood, and deterring the one who opposes it.

Shaykh al-Islām said, when mentioning this principle:

“For this reason, the Prophet ﷺ would win some people over while boycotting others.”

And someone said:

“The obligations of the Shari‘ah became difficult, so every idle deceiver turned away from them.

So hold firmly to the rope of the religion of Aḥmad;

do not let position or status deceive you.

Follow the path of gentleness in conveying it,

devoting yourself sincerely to Allah.”